was well tutored by my staff for this ‘inquisition’, there would invariably be questions, or at any rate nuances on questions, which we had not thought of. I valued the opportunity of the media interaction as it was a useful platform for us to disseminate the rationale and expected outcomes of the policy in spoken and simpler language. It was a space where we could put out clear messages and oftentimes even explain some of the dilemmas we went through. In one interaction, I volunteered that opinion among my advisers too was divided on the policy action. Some of the media personnel were surprised that I would be so transparent but I thought communicating that the policy decision was finely balanced had its own signalling impact.

In an effort to improve the quality of our dissemination of the policy, we introduced a teleconference of analysts targeting a range of non-media stakeholders predominantly from the financial sector, but also drawing from the corporate world and academia. Deputy Governor Subir Gokarn was the inspiration behind this. The idea was to allow a day for the analysts to absorb the policy as also for an initial reaction by the media so that the questions would be more thought through. At the same time, the analysts’ teleconference allowed those of us within the Reserve Bank an opportunity, through our responses, to reinforce some of the messages or correct any overt misinterpretation. I was pleased to see the teleconference rapidly gaining in popularity with not only the numbers signing up from both within the country and outside increasing, but also the depth and quality of questions improving.

Monetary Policy Outreach

The monetary policy process is anchored in the monetary policy department of the Reserve Bank, and even there only a handful of senior officers are in the loop about the entire process and on the final decision. On the other hand, the Reserve Bank is so quintessentially identified with monetary policy that the larger public sees every staff member of the Reserve Bank as having had a say in making the policy. Imagine a situation where a middle-level officer, say in the non-bank supervision department of the Reserve